

pened during the Sassanian age does not concern us. I should, however, remind those who read detailed comparisons in the work of Bousset or Böklen that the antiquity of material to be found in the Pahlavi books is subject to the greatest uncertainty. We may be dealing with faithfully produced translations of old Avestan texts now lost, or with doctrines of medieval post-Sassanian Parsism. When we add to this the problems of date presented by the material collected in the Talmud, it is clear that the question of interlacing dependence is likely to be often insoluble. Happily, I am able to pass it by, and go back to Babylon as the place of contact, according to Bousset, the most important champion of the theory of Iranian influence on Judaism. It may be well to quote his summary (*Judentum*, p. 548):

The place where Parsism and Judaism came in contact was Babylon and the Babylonian plain. In Babylon, as we have said, was the centre of Jewish religion after the Exile. And there are many indications that on the other side Iranian religion had overflowed its ancient bounds and pushed its way far into the west, and in any case had attained the predominance in the old Babylonian mother-country. When Alexander the Great made his expedition to Babylon, there met him in the front rank the "Magi" or Persian priests, and in the second the Chaldæans, the priests of the Babylonian religion.¹ In Greek tradition

¹ Bousset quotes Quintus Curtius, who gives us the order of the procession which met Alexander when he entered Babylon after Arbela. After the captain of the citadel and the presents he brought came the Magi:—Magi deinde suo more carmen canentes, post hos Chaldaei Babyloniorumque non vates modo, sed etiam artifices cum fidibus sui generis ibant, laudes hi regum canere soliti, Chaldaei siderum motus et statas vices temporum ostendere. So